The call

A structure for talking to leads, built on Jeremy Miner's NEPQ question sequence and the behavioural side of Chase Hughes' work.

What this takes from each, and what it leaves. From NEPQ: the sequence, the tonality, and the rule that the prospect has to say the problem out loud before you say anything about a solution. From Hughes: pacing, attention, authority without dominance, and reading which state someone is actually in rather than the one you assumed. What it leaves out is the covert-influence end of that material — not on principle alone, but because it does not work here. You are selling to an owner who will do arithmetic on it afterwards, and anything that feels like it was done *to* them dies at the second call or the first invoice.

The whole method is one idea: **they will not believe your number, and they cannot argue with their own.** Every question below exists to get them saying it instead of you.

The crib sheet — glance at this mid-call

Tone	Curious, slightly concerned. Never bright and salesy. Down at the end of a question, not up.
Ratio	They talk 70%. If you are talking more, you are pitching too early.
After a question	Stop. Count to three. The silence is doing the work.
Never	Say a price before they have said a number.
The pivot	"How are you handling that right now?"
The close	"Do you want to just try it and see?"
If they stall	"Sounds like it might not be a priority right now — should I leave it?"

Before you dial — two minutes

Have open: their Google listing, whether they run ads, review count and rating. The command centre has this on the prospect already, and `playbook.js` builds a vertical-specific opener from it.

Know your one number for their vertical:

- **Law:** one signed case is worth $3,000–$5,000+ in fees
- **Medical / dental:** one booked patient $75–$300, aesthetics far higher
- **Home services:** one job $200–$2,000+

You are not going to say that number. They are.

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1. Connection — lower the guard, 20 seconds

The first job is not interest. It is getting them out of the posture everyone adopts when a stranger calls to sell.

> *"Hi — this is [name] with Sanaku. I'll be honest, I'm not sure this is even relevant to you. Can I ask one question and then get out of your way?"*

Two things are doing work. Admitting you might not be a fit removes the thing they were bracing for. Asking permission for *one* question is a small, easy yes — and the first yes is the one that costs the most.

Match their pace immediately. A contractor answering from a truck is short and fast; be short and fast. A practice manager at a desk has more room. Talking at your own tempo instead of theirs is the fastest way to sound like a call centre.

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2. Situation — get the picture, no selling

Neutral, factual, easy to answer. You are building the frame they will later judge themselves against.

> *"When your team is on a job and the phone rings — where does that call go?"*
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> *"Roughly how many calls come in a week? Ballpark is fine."*
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> *"And who picks up after five?"*

Do not react to the answers yet. Do not say "right, so what we do is—".

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3. Problem awareness — the sale happens here

This is the part most people skip and it is the only part that matters. You are not informing them of a problem. You are asking questions that make them notice one they already had.

> *"How do you know when you've missed one?"*
>
> *"What happens to that person — do they wait, or do they call the next place?"*
>
> *"Has that been a problem, or is it not really an issue?"*

That last one is deliberate. Offering them the exit makes the answer true. If they say it is not an issue, believe them and stop — you have saved you both a half hour. Most will not.

Tone check. These are asked with genuine curiosity, not as a trap. If it sounds like you already know the answer, it lands as an accusation and they defend.

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4. Consequence — let them do the arithmetic

Now the numbers, and they say all of them.

> *"Out of, say, ten of those — how many do you think you get back?"*
>
> *"And what's one of those jobs worth to you, roughly?"*
>
> *(silence — let them multiply)*

Then, only once they have said both:

> *"So that's about $[their number] a month walking out the door. Is that roughly how you see it, or am I overstating it?"*

Ask if you are overstating it. They will correct you *downward* and then defend the corrected figure as their own. A number they argued you down to is worth ten of a number you gave them.

If they will not put numbers on it, send the leak calculator and book a second call. Do not guess on their behalf.

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5. Solution awareness — still asking, not telling

> *"If those calls got answered — every one, at 2am, in your name — what would that be worth fixing?"*
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> *"What have you tried already?"*

That second question matters. If they have used Podium, Weave or an answering service, you need to know before you pitch, because your positioning changes entirely (see objections).

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6. Only now — the offer, in three sentences

Do not present features. Present the mechanism and get out.

> *"So what we'd do is put an agent on your line that picks up on the second ring, asks the three things that qualify the job, and texts you the summary. It's under your name and your number — customers never see us. You'd pay the setup to have it built, never more than $750 up front, then run it for thirty days before there's any monthly fee. If it doesn't catch more than it costs, you walk and you keep the leads it caught."*

Then stop talking.

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7. The strongest close you have — make them hear it

> *"Rather than me describing it — do you want to just call it? I'll text you the number, it picks up as a plumbing company, ask it whatever you'd ask. Takes a minute."*

Nothing you say competes with them hearing the thing work. If the demo line is live, use it on every call. It converts skepticism into curiosity faster than any explanation, and it costs about twenty cents.

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8. Commitment

Never "does that sound good?" — that invites a polite no.

> *"What would need to be true for this to be worth trying?"*

Then whatever they say, that is the close. If they say "I'd need to see it works" — that is the trial, and you have already described it.

Ending on price:

> *"Setup is $[their service], then nothing for thirty days. Want me to get your number registered so the clock can start?"*

Objections

"We already have someone answering."

> *"Good — then this only fires when they can't. It's silent when your team catches it. What happens at 7pm, or when they're on the other line?"*

"How much?" Never answer with a number alone; answer with the comparison they already made.

> *"Setup, then $[monthly] a month. Against [their number] a month walking out the door — does that feel like the wrong shape, or just something to check?"*

"We use Podium / Weave already." Do not fight on features — you lose, they are whole platforms.

> *"Then you've got the software. The gap is usually that someone has to set it up and keep it tuned. We're not selling you a tool, we run it for you and it answers in your voice. If Podium's already catching them, honestly, keep it."*

That last sentence is not a concession. It is what makes the rest credible.

"It's a robot, my customers will hate it."

> *"Some will. It says up front that it's an assistant — we don't pretend otherwise. The question is whether an assistant that answers beats a voicemail that doesn't. Call the demo line and judge it yourself."*

"Send me some information." Usually a soft no. Test it once, kindly.

> *"Happy to. Can I ask — is that a 'this isn't for us', or a 'not right now'? Either's fine, I'd just rather not clutter your inbox."*

What will lose the deal

- **Pitching before stage 3.** The commonest failure. If you have described the

product and they have not described a problem, you are presenting to someone with no reason to listen.

- **Quoting a price before they have quoted a number.** Every figure sounds

large in a vacuum and small next to a leak.

- **Selling what is not built.** Only some of the catalog is deliverable today.

The sell sheet marks which. Promising a nurture sequence you cannot switch on costs you the client at week two, not week one.

- **Overselling the AI.** It answers, qualifies and books. It does not close, it

does not sell, it does not judge. Say that first and you never have to retreat to it.

Two things you may not say

Not sales advice. These are enforced in the database and they are on the compliance line of every relevant service.

To a law firm: per-lead means per *intake delivered*, never per case signed, and never a share of fees or recoveries. That is fee-splitting with a non-lawyer in most states. The agent also states it is not a lawyer and gives no legal advice — say so on the call, because it is the first thing a careful attorney will ask.

To a medical or dental practice: flat fee only. Never per patient — that can implicate anti-kickback and fee-splitting rules. And nothing goes live until a BAA is signed with every vendor in the call path. Do not agree a start date before that paperwork exists.

The line worth repeating

Every lead billed is logged with a timestamp the client can audit — billed from your own meter, never from anything they report to you.

Say it early. It is the most credible sentence you have, it costs nothing, and it is the thing a burned buyer is actually listening for.